AI Digitalise

Brief: the whole project in one sitting

Digitalise Agency

2026-08-11

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1 What it is, and the one thing to know first

This repository holds a marketing web page for **ai.digitalise.agency**: one page, dark navy, whose job is to convince a visitor that Digitalise Agency can build AI systems for them and then get them to book a call.

Six files, 1,591 lines, no framework, no build step, no package manager, no database and no server code. That is unusual enough in 2026 to be worth stating as a decision rather than an absence.

This is not the page being served at that address

The design here was finished, then deliberately parked. On 2026-07-29 a single commit moved every file into a folder called `new-design-reference/` and renamed the publishing workflow so it could no longer run. Its message says why: the live site is a different build, produced elsewhere.

Fetching `https://ai.digitalise.agency/` on 2026-08-11 confirms it. The address answers with `200` and serves a page with a different title entirely. Read this repository as a design reference, never as the live site.

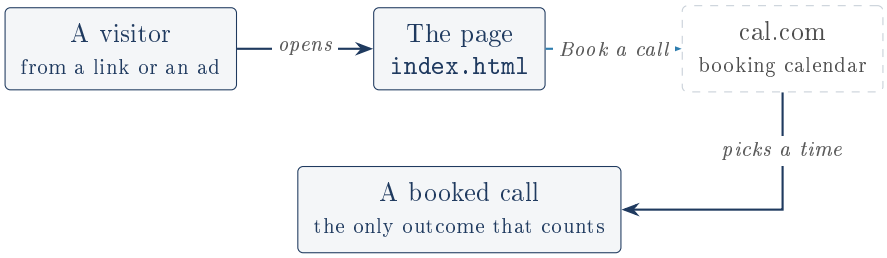


Figure 1: The entire purpose. Dashed boxes are services the agency does not run.

Jargon: Repository

A folder whose complete change history is recorded by a program called git, so every edit can be listed, inspected and undone.

2 The mental model

A web page is made of three kinds of file. This project has exactly one of each, plus three files that are about hosting rather than about the page.

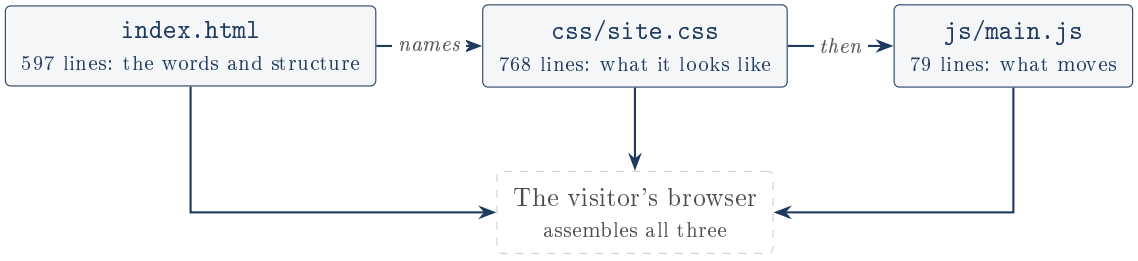


Figure 2: Nothing runs on a server. Everything happens on the visitor's machine.

The arrows only point one way

`index.html` names the other two files. Neither knows anything about it: the stylesheet styles class names it hopes exist, and the JavaScript looks for elements that may not be there, with

a guard at every lookup so it does nothing quietly when they are missing.
That is why the page never crashes, and why a mistyped class name produces something that looks wrong rather than something that reports an error. Nothing anywhere checks that the three files agree with each other.

3 How it works, end to end

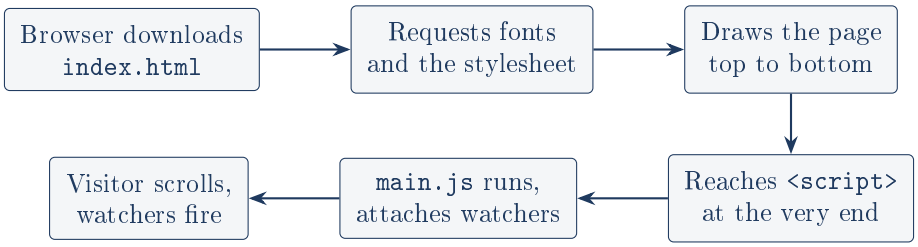


Figure 3: One page view, start to finish.

The page stacks nine bands: a fixed navigation bar, a full-screen hero with eight small cards drifting behind it, four large statistics, a five-step pipeline diagram, six portfolio cards, three client result cards, six service tiles, a booking panel, and a one-line footer.

Three things then react to scrolling, and that is the whole of the interactivity:

1. the navigation bar grows a frosted dark background past 40 pixels of scroll;
2. the four statistics count up from zero over 2.2 seconds when they come into view;
3. most blocks fade upward into place as they arrive.

There is no form, nothing is saved, and nothing is sent anywhere. The only outbound action a visitor can take is following the booking link, which opens a cal.com calendar in a new tab.

Nothing measures whether the page works

No analytics of any kind: no counter, no tag manager, no event when somebody presses “Book a call”. The one question the page exists to answer cannot be answered from the page. Whether that is a privacy choice or an oversight is not recorded anywhere, so this document does not guess.

4 The main components

File	Kind	Lines	What it does
`new-design-reference/index.html`	HTML	597	Every word on the page, and its structure. Holds all the icons as inline drawings
`new-design-reference/css/site.css`	CSS	768	All appearance, layout, movement, and the two mobile layouts
`new-design-reference/js/main.js`	JavaScript	79	The three scroll behaviours, with no dependencies at all
`new-design-reference/netlify.toml`	config	11	Hosting settings for a host this project does not use
`new-design-reference/assets/ASSETS.md`	notes	33	A checklist of twelve assets, none of which were ever produced
`.github/workflows-disabled/deploy.yml.disabled`	workflow	103	The publishing pipeline, switched off

Table 1: Every file git tracks. The Deep Dive walks all six line by line, in sections 7.1 to 7.6.

4.1 `index.html`: the page

The content and the structure. It is unusually self-contained: every icon is an SVG drawing written directly into the file rather than loaded as an image, so the page needs no image downloads at all.

Two of its habits are worth knowing before you edit it. First, appearance is sometimes written directly onto elements with `style` attributes rather than left to the stylesheet, and an inline style always wins, which is how one stylesheet rule ends up permanently overridden. Second, the four statistics keep their real values in `data-` attributes and display the character `0` until JavaScript replaces it. Deep Dive section 7.1.

4.2 `site.css`: the design system

The most valuable file in the repository, and the one worth borrowing. It opens with twenty named values (the "tokens") covering surfaces, text, accents, borders, typefaces, radii, a motion curve and a content width. Its own second line records where the scheme came from: the tokens mirror those of the Gantry project elsewhere in this workspace.

Why the token names are numbers rather than colours

Calling a colour `-s1` instead of `-dark-navy` names what it is *for* (the surface one step up from the page) rather than how it looks. Redesign in a light theme and `-s1` still means the right thing while `-dark-navy` becomes a lie. This is the single most transferable idea in the repository.

It ends with the best thing in the project: a block that honours the visitor's reduced-motion preference, crushing every animation to nothing *and* forcing the fade-in elements to full opacity so they still appear. That second half is the detail most implementations get wrong. Deep Dive section 7.2.

4.3 `main.js`: the three behaviours

Seventy-nine lines, no dependencies, and better written than its size suggests: a single wrapper keeping its names private, a guard at every lookup, a small shared helper built on `IntersectionObserver` that four one-line calls then reuse, and correct use of the flags that keep scrolling smooth and stop each animation firing twice.

Its interface with the rest of the project is seven strings: three selectors, two class names it adds, and two more it looks up. Break any one of them and the page keeps working, minus one behaviour, silently. Deep Dive section 7.3.

4.4 The three files about hosting

`netlify.toml` declares four sensible security headers for a hosting service this project does not use. `ASSETS.md` lists the twelve assets needed to finish the design, none of which exist. The workflow publishes the site to the agency's server when a commit subject begins with `[deploy]`, and it is switched off. Deep Dive sections 7.4 to 7.6.

5 How it is operated

5.1 Looking at it locally

```
cd new-design-reference
python3 -m http.server 8000
# then open http://localhost:8000/
```

Listing 1: Serve it, do not open the file directly

Opening `index.html` straight off the disk renders it completely unstyled, which looks like catastrophic breakage and is not. The page asks for its stylesheet at `/css/site.css`, and the leading slash means "from the top of the site", which off a disk is the root of your hard drive. This one character is the most likely thing to make a newcomer think the project is broken.

5.2 Publishing

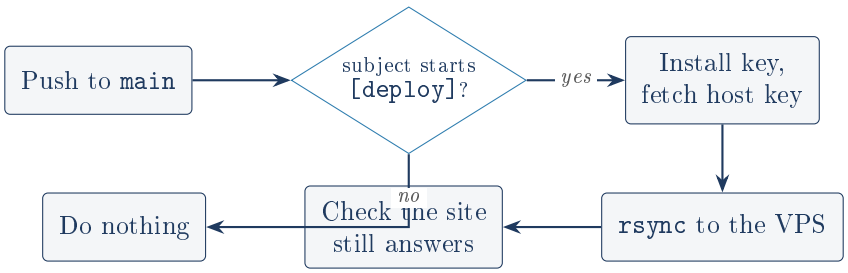


Figure 4: The publishing pipeline as written. Drawn for reference: it is switched off, twice over, and has been since 2026-07-29.

The `[deploy]` marker must *begin* the commit subject line. Writing "fix the header and [deploy]" does nothing at all. This convention is shared by every repository in this workspace.

The workflow is disabled two ways: its folder is named `.github/workflows-disabled` rather than `.github/workflows`, and the file ends in `.disabled` rather than `.yml`. Either alone would be enough, which tells you the intent was not to pause it briefly.

5.3 Claude Code tooling

This project ships none, which was checked rather than assumed: there is no `.claude/` folder, no `CLAUDE.md`, no skill and no hook.

There is no README either, and that matters more than it sounds. The central fact about this repository, that it is parked and the live site is elsewhere, exists only in a commit message, invisible unless somebody thinks to run `git log`.

The two PDFs in `docs/explainer/` are produced by a workspace-level command, `/explain-projects`, which lives outside this repository.

6 Configuration and deployment at a glance

Nothing is configurable at run time: no settings file, no environment file. Three values behave like configuration and are written into the source:

Value	Where	Controls
`https://cal.com/davonex/30min`	`index.html` line 565	which calendar opens
`hello@digitalise.agency`	`index.html` line 590	the footer contact
The twenty colour tokens	`site.css` lines 5–25	the entire colour scheme

Table 2: Values that behave like settings.

The repository holds no passwords, keys or tokens, and it should not: a page that runs entirely in a visitor's browser can keep no secret. Three secrets are stored in GitHub and referenced by the workflow (`VPS_HOST`, `VPS_USER`, `VPS_SSH_KEY`); the server's IP address is also written into a comment in that same file, which defeats the point of storing it as a secret.

The page has exactly two run-time dependencies, both reached by the visitor's browser: Google Fonts for two typefaces, and cal.com for the booking calendar.

7 Honest findings

The Deep Dive argues each of these at the line where it arises. Summarized:

7.1 Correctness

- **The live site's canonical link points at another domain.** The page currently served at ai.digitalise.agency declares `salmanadnan.com` as its canonical URL, which asks search engines to index that site instead. Verified live on 2026-08-11. It cannot be fixed from this repository, and whoever maintains the live build should know.
- **Restoring the deploy workflow unchanged would break the live site.** It copies the repository root, which since the move contains a folder rather than a home page, and it copies with `-delete`.
- **A failed post-deploy check is only a warning**, so the workflow would finish green even if the site never came back after an `rsync -delete`.

7.2 Unfinished work

- **None of the twelve assets in `ASSETS.md` exist**, including the favicon and the social preview image. Portfolio thumbnails are still colour gradients and client logos are still lettered circles.
- **Five "UPDATE" comments** remain in `index.html` marking work that may or may not have been done, and two of the three instructions in `ASSETS.md` refer to code that no longer exists.
- **The booking link is a placeholder**, pointing at another project's calendar. The same placeholder is a known outstanding item on the agency's main website, so it is a shared loose end rather than a local slip.
- **One client avatar shows the wrong initial**, a survivor of the placeholder set.

7.3 Presentation

The hero backdrop displays invented engagement numbers

The eight drifting cards show 847K views, 234K impressions, 1.2M, 512K, 1.8M and 19K reactions. None is a measurement; they arrived fully formed in the first commit. They are hidden from screen readers and are plainly decorative, but a sighted visitor reads them as claims.
This is worth naming because the same author set a higher standard elsewhere in the same repository: `ASSETS.md` asks that the four large statistics be "verified from Gantry / n8n data", meaning traceable to the agency's own systems.

Also: the six portfolio cards show a play button on hover and play nothing, and the footer link reads `digitalise.agency` while pointing at this site.

7.4 Accessibility

- **The counting numbers ignore the reduced-motion preference.** The stylesheet honours it meticulously; the JavaScript never checks. The intent is demonstrably there and simply was not carried into the other file. Four lines fix it, given in Deep Dive section 7.3.
- **Neither button has a focus state**, so keyboard navigation relies on whatever outline the browser draws, which on a dark background is often nearly invisible. These are the page's only interactive elements.
- **The small blue uppercase labels are worth a contrast measurement.** This document does not have one and so raises it rather than asserting a failure.

7.5 Dead and contradictory code

Two colour tokens defined and never read; one stylesheet rule targeting a class no element carries; one rule permanently overridden by inline styles; three lines of responsive code that show a tile and then hide it again; a doubled flex layout in the navigation; smooth scrolling implemented twice, once in CSS and once in JavaScript, where the JavaScript copy also carries a latent crash; a class added by JavaScript that nothing styles; and a whole hosting configuration file for a host that is not used.

8 The story, in brief

8.1 What it delivered

A complete, self-contained one-page marketing site with no dependencies to install; a hosting configuration setting four security headers; a GitHub Actions workflow that publishes over SSH with retries and a post-deploy check; and an asset checklist. What it did not deliver is a live site.

8.2 When it was built

Nine commits across two calendar days, 2026-07-28 and 2026-07-29, and nothing since. The shape of that history is the interesting part: the first day is the design and the second day is almost entirely deployment. Four of the five commits on the second day fix the publishing pipeline, and the fifth switches it off.

This is calendar time, not effort. Git records when commits happened and nothing about hours spent, and no document in the repository records effort, so none is claimed.

8.3 The four challenges that mattered

Each is claimed because the repository carries a scar for it.

1. **SSH access to the server**, fixed across three consecutive commits: secrets missing, then the wrong key, then a `deploy` user without permission to traverse into `/root`. That last one is genuinely unobvious and its workaround survives in three `rsync` flags.
2. **GitHub's runners being refused by the server.** Two independent retry loops were written into a fifty-line script, and the sibling repository `salmanadnan-com` carries a commit titled "Retry, runner IP lottery", which confirms the diagnosis.
3. **Em-dashes.** One commit exists solely to remove them, which is the workspace house rule showing up as real work.
4. **Being overtaken.** The final commit is a retreat, not a fix: the page was finished and working when something else became the live site. That is the largest challenge here and it was not technical.

8.4 Where it stands

Built, complete, responsive, and parked. Superseded by a different build at the same address. Never finished as a product, since none of its own launch checklist was delivered. Dormant since 2026-07-29.

8.5 Do and do not

From here on this is advice and judgement, not a record of decisions.

Do:

- Read `git log` before touching anything: it holds the only statement of this repository's status.
- Serve the folder over HTTP to view it, never open the file directly.
- Keep the `[deploy]` convention and both retry loops if the workflow is ever restored. They were paid for.
- Treat the stylesheet as the reusable asset. It is a coherent dark theme in 768 readable lines with no tooling.

Do not:

- Re-enable the deploy workflow without changing the `rsync` source path. It would copy a folder instead of a page and take the live site down with it.
- Copy the hero tiles into anything real without replacing their numbers.
- Trust `ASSETS.md`. Two of its three instructions describe code that no longer exists.
- Assume this repository is what visitors see. It is not, and that is the easiest mistake to make here.
- Delete the repository because it is not live. The stylesheet is reusable and the workflow encodes three separate lessons about SSH on GitHub runners.

8.6 What would change, starting over

Opinion, argued from the code. Keep all of it: the no-build-step decision, the token block, the three-behaviour JavaScript and the reduced-motion handling are right for a page this size, and a framework would have added a hundred times the machinery for nothing a visitor could perceive.

Change five things. Write a README on day one saying what the site is and where it is served from, because its absence is what makes this repository confusing. Use a relative stylesheet

path so it can be opened off a disk. Self-host the two fonts, matching the agency's own main site. Produce the favicon and social image before the first deploy rather than listing them. And delete a placeholder comment in the same commit that removes the placeholder.

Drop `netlify.toml` entirely, or move its four security headers into the Caddy configuration on the server so they actually take effect.

8.7 Open threads

Twelve assets never produced; a placeholder booking calendar shared with the agency's main site; five stale `UPDATE` comments; an undocumented sibling relationship with the `salmanadnan-com` repository, which shares an identical file list and was built the same week; and the canonical link on the live site pointing at the wrong domain.

9 Glossary

ARIA
Attributes beginning `aria-` that describe a page to screen readers. They change nothing visually.

Breakpoint
A screen width at which the layout changes. This project has two, at 900 and 600 pixels.

Class
A label attached to elements so CSS and JavaScript can find them.

clamp
A CSS function taking a minimum, a preferred value and a maximum, used here so headings scale with the window between fixed limits.

CSS
Cascading Style Sheets: the file controlling appearance.

Custom property
A named value in CSS, written `-name` and read back with `var(-name)`. The "tokens" are these.

Data attribute
An attribute beginning `data-` that HTML ignores and JavaScript can read. The four statistics keep their real values in these.

Flexbox
A layout system arranging children in a row or column.

Grid
A layout system arranging children in rows and columns at once.

HTML
HyperText Markup Language: the file holding content and structure.

IntersectionObserver
A browser facility reporting when an element scrolls into view. All three scroll behaviours are built on it.

JavaScript
The language running in the browser after the page loads.

Media query
CSS applying only when a condition about the screen is true.

prefers-reduced-motion
A system setting asking pages to avoid animation, usually because it causes nausea or migraine. The stylesheet honours it; the JavaScript does not.

Pseudo-element
An extra box CSS creates with no tag in the HTML, written `::before` or `::after`, used here for the pipeline's flowing lines and the glow above the booking panel.

rsync
A program that copies files between computers, transferring only what differs.

Selector
The part of a CSS rule saying which elements it applies to.

SSH
Secure Shell: the standard way to connect to another computer securely.

SVG
A picture described as shapes and coordinates rather than pixels, so it stays sharp at any size and can sit inside the HTML file.

Token
In this project, one of the twenty named values at the top of the stylesheet.

VPS
Virtual Private Server: a rented computer the agency controls remotely.

Workflow
A file describing a job GitHub runs automatically when something happens in the repository.

For the full treatment, including every line of every file with its provenance, its connections and its failure modes, see `docs/explainer/deep-dive.pdf` in this same folder.